

[Return to Search](#)

Dominance and defiance

Author(S): Cohen, Ronald

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 42

Culture (OWC): [Kanuri \(MS14\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1955-57, 1965-66

Coverage Date: 1955 - 1966

Place Coverage: Borno State, Nigeria

Section Title(S): Behavior Norms

Joking relations are in one sense the lowest level of the respect scale. In such relationships the customary restrictions and demands upon behavior based on seniority, generation, sex, or any other status differences, are relaxed. They are instead replaced by formalized patterns of permissiveness in which the junior becomes the equal of the senior, and therefore a putative and formalized kind of reciprocity can be established.

[577](#)
[Ethics](#)

[602](#)
[Kin Relationships](#)

Finally, there is *numkam* or relatedness. At first I took this term to mean friendship and an egalitarian relationship between social equals. Informants claimed that for relatives with no special request, or joking, and no shame, there is *numkam* "and therefore they are friends." Although there is a perfectly good word for friendship (*soba*), this seemed to be a synonym. Later, however, I realized that such people are friends *because* they are related. Relatedness (*numkam*) can consequently be used in a number of ways. First, it can refer to any kind of relationship, next it can refer to kinship connections, and more restricted yet, it can be used to refer to relationships within the kinship network that are not necessarily governed by the respect scale. This leaves only

[577](#)
[Ethics](#)

[602](#)
[Kin Relationships](#)

TABLE 4:1. BEHAVIORAL NORMS FOR COGNATIC KIN IN 0 TO +3 GENERATIONS *

<i>Kin type</i>	<i>Shame</i>		<i>Respect</i>		<i>Joking</i>		<i>Friendship</i>		<i>No Data</i>	
	No.	%	No.	%	No.	%	No.	%	No.	%

[577](#)
[Ethics](#)

[602](#)
[Kin Relationships](#)

Father	47	96	48	98	0	0	0	0	0	0
Mother	47	96	48	98	0	0	0	0	0	0
Fa Sis Chi	15	31	5	11	1	2	33	73	4	8
Fa Bro	14	29	47	96	2	4	9	18	0	0
Mo Bro	13	27	43	88	1	2	10	20	0	0
Mo Sis	12	24	46	94	2	4	7	14	0	0
Fa Sis	12	24	46	94	1	2	7	14	0	0
Mo Bro Chi	11	24	7	15	2	4	33	72	3	6
Ol Bro	8	18	35	80	0	0	21	48	5	10
Ol Sis	8	18	35	80	1	3	20	45	5	10
Mo Sis Chi	6	14	10	23	3	7	27	61	5	10
Fa Bro Chi	4	8	5	11	2	4	40	87	3	6
Yo Bro	0	0	1	3	3	8	31	86	13	26
Yo Sis	0	0	5	13	4	10	28	72	10	20
G+/G/Parent	0	0	8	17	47	100	0	0	2	4
G/Parent	0	0	7	14	48	98	0	0	0	0

Table Notes:

Columns
headed no.
indicate the
number of
persons
claiming
such a
relationship.
Columns
headed %
indicate the
percent of
the total
sample who
answered
positively.

Columns headed no. indicate the number of persons claiming such a relationship. Columns headed % indicate the percent of the total sample who answered positively.



Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)